United Against the Siang Project

A kind for kind strategic reply to China's mammoth upstream dam in Tibet runs into local resistance

India's proposed 11,200 MW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project (SUMP) in Arunachal Pradesh is caught in a tangle of local opposition. Conceived as a hydropower and infrastructure initiative, it is claimed that the project on the Siang river will help manage water-related risks by being a strategic buffer to China's Medog dam project further upstream. The agitation centres on drilling and other work for the project's pre-feasibility study without the consent of local communities. Many fear that it would lead to displacement, widespread environmental damage and loss of ancestral lands.

The Siang river originates in Tibet as the Yarlung Tsangpo, before it enters Arunachal and then flows into Assam as the Brahmaputra. In July 2025, China began constructing a massive, 60,000 MW hydropower project near the Tsangpo's 'great bend' in Tibet. The project has heightened Indian concerns about downstream water security and floods. In August 2026, India urged China to resume sharing Tsangpo waterflow data and provide information about upstream infrastructure. For India, limited Chinese transparency has made the disruption of Siang-Brahmaputra's water flow a possibility.



A roadblock by anti-dam protesters

Officials claim that the Siang dam's storage and flow-regulation capabilities would help moderate flood events. Associated infrastructure would improve connectivity and create employment too.

Experts say that independent environmental assessments, fair compensation and rehabilitation plans are essential, particularly in a seismically active region. Geeta Kochhar, senior assistant professor at JNU's Centre for Chinese Studies, says, "As China expands its upstream dams, a large reservoir could help India manage sudden changes in river flows," while adding that the concerns are legitimate and require credible safeguards.

Chaudhary estimates that a substantial portion of the work in Arunachal Pradesh remains unfinished.

The government has, nevertheless, accelerated infrastructure construction in recent years. In December 2025, defence minister Rajnath Singh inaugurated 32 BRO infrastructure projects in Arunachal Pradesh, including roads, tunnels, bridges and a helipad-related initiative. Project Brahmank of the BRO maintains 811 km of roads and 86 bridges across the sensitive border districts of Siang, West Siang, Upper Siang and Shi-Yomi. Under the central Vibrant Villages Programme, the state has approved 1,022 km of strategic roads worth Rs 2,205 crore to provide last-mile connectivity for 126 critical border villages across 11 districts.

INDIA HAS RESPONDED TO CHINA'S XIAOKANG SETTLEMENTS WITH ITS OWN VIBRANT VILLAGES PROGRAMME, WHICH INCLUDES 455 VILLAGES IN ARUNACHAL PRADESH

India's infrastructure drive is unfolding alongside China's border settlements or villages under its Xiaokang programme, with a substantial number of 628 villages facing Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh. With roads, telecommunications and infrastructure, they improve logistics, surveillance and mobility at the LAC for China.

Militarily, China's approach combines forward border defence units, with larger Combined Arms Brigades (CABs)—integrating infantry with armour, artillery, air defence, logistics and electronic warfare—for greater support. Its road rail and air infrastructure across Tibet can facilitate swift mobilisation too.

India, meanwhile, benefits from long-established military deployments, local terrain knowledge, airlift capabilities and a fast expanding road network. Its priorities are to improve forward access and strengthen supply lines, expand surveillance, ensure reliable communications and thus increase its capacity to respond to local incidents quickly and effectively. ■